

Session 6: The Birth of Jesus

Key Takeaways

- Matthew highlights Joseph's righteousness, establishing an important pattern of characters who answer the call to do right by God.
- The Spirit miraculously brings about Jesus' conception within Mary's womb, echoing the biblical pattern of the Spirit of God bringing new life in unexpected places.
- Jesus' name means "Yahweh will rescue," and his name connects to the hoped for messiah who will restore Israel's kingdom and to Greek and Roman ideas about the good news of a king who is savior of the world.

Matthew 1:18-2:23 — The Birth of the Messiah

Matthew 1:18-25

A - Jesus Is Conceived

- a - 1:18-21 Mary **pregnant** by Holy Spirit, **angel "appears" (phaino)** to Joseph, "**take Mary**"
- b - 1:22-23 **Old Testament quote 1 (Isa. 7:14)**
- a' - 1:24-25 Joseph obeys **angelic dream**, **takes Mary**, who **births a son**: Jesus

Matthew 2:1-12

B - Jesus Is Born

- a - 2:1-3 Jesus was **born** in **Bethlehem**, magi see **star** in the east and come to **worship**, Herod hears
- b - 2:4-6 Herod's inquiry to Messiah's **birth** town: **Old Testament quote 2 (Mic. 5:4)**
- a' - 2:7-12 **Star "appears" (phaino)**, leads Magi to child, **worship**, magi **dream** & depart

Matthew 2:13-23

A' - Jesus' Exile & Return

- a - 2:13-15 Joseph's **angelic dream**, "take child and Mary to Egypt" + **Old Testament quote 3 (Hos. 11:1)**
- b - 2:16-18 Herod **murders the sons** of Bethlehem + **Old Testament quote 4 (Jer. 31:17)**
- a' - 2:19-23 Joseph's **angelic dream**, "take child and Mary back to Israel" + **Old Testament quote 5 (Isa 11:1)**

Matthew has pulled together five episodes in the story of infant Jesus and organized them into three bundles.

1. Unit 1 (Matthew 1:18-25)
 - Episode 1: Mary's pregnancy, Joseph's marriage to Mary, the birth of Jesus
2. Unit 2 (Matthew 2:1-12)
 - Episode 2: The visit of the magi from the East
3. Unit 3 (Matthew 2:13-23)
 - Episode 3: Joseph takes Mary and Jesus, leaves Israel, and goes to Egypt
 - Episode 4: Herod's massacre of Israelite boys in Bethlehem
 - Episode 5: Joseph takes Mary and Jesus, leaves Egypt, and goes to Israel and Nazareth

By organizing the stories in this way, Matthew has shaped each of the three units in a symmetrical design, inviting the reader to notice hyperlinks and narrative analogies.

Stars and angels: The presence of guiding angels and dreams in A (1:18-25) and A' (2:13-23) allows the reader to see the dream and shining star of the magi story in B (2:1-12) as parallel. Specifically, Matthew uses the same word "shine/appear" (φαίνω, 1:23/2:13) to describe the angel and the star, leading readers to conclude that the star guiding the magi is, in fact, an angel.

Hebrew Bible quotes: Notice how the Hebrew Bible quotes in units 1 and 2 occupy the central panels of the story, while in unit 3, a quotation occurs in all three panels of the story, giving it a climactic role in the sequence of stories.

The death and life of sons: Notice how the birth of Jesus in unit 1 is contrasted with the murder of the sons in unit 3.

Joseph "takes" Mary: In unit 1, the angels direct Joseph to "take" (παραλαμβάνω) Mary in marriage (Matt. 1:20) to protect her reputation. In unit 3, the angel again directs Joseph to "take" (παραλαμβάνω) Mary (Matt. 2:13, 19) to and from Egypt, again to protect her, but this time also to save her baby's life.

Matthew 1:18-25

¹⁸ Now, the **birth-beginning** (γενεσις) of **Jesus Messiah** was this way:

- A
- a His mother, **Maria**,
 - b having been **engaged** to **Joseph**,
 - b' **before they had come together**,
 - a' she was found to **have in the womb by the Holy Spirit**,

- a ¹⁹ and **Joseph her husband**,
- b being a righteous one,

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b' and not desiring to make her a public spectacle,
a' **he** wanted to send **her** away privately.

20 And while he was thinking about these things,
look, **a messenger of the Lord** appeared to him in **a dream**, saying,

a' "Ioseph, **son of David**,
do not be afraid **to take Maria** as your **wife**,
A' b' because what has been **birthed inside her**
is from the Holy Spirit,

a' 21 and she will **birth** a **son**,
and **you will call his name Iesous**,
because he will **save** his people from their moral-failings."

a' 22 And all of this happened
so that what was spoken by the Lord through the prophet would be filled-full, saying,
b' 23 "Look, **the virgin** will **have in the womb** and will **birth** a **son**,
and **they will call his name Emmanuel**,
a' which is translated ' **With Us Is God** .'"

24 And, after **Ioseph** got up from **sleep**,
he did as **the messenger of the Lord** commanded him,
and **he took his wife**,
25 and **he did not know her** until she **birthed** a **son**,
and he called his name **Iesous**.

Matthew 1:18-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

This compact presentation of Mary's pregnancy and Joseph's response has been clearly organized in a three-part sequence.

A — Narrative (v. 18-21): Mary's pregnancy, angelic message to Joseph

B — Narrator's comment (v. 22-23): Fulfillment quotation

A' — Narrative (v. 24-25): Mary gives birth, Joseph's obedient response to angelic message

Joseph's Point of View

The opening birth story of Jesus is told entirely from Joseph's point of view, whereas Luke's account is told with an emphasis on Mary's experience. Matthew highlights many facets of Joseph's character, both explicitly and implicitly.

Explicit characterization of Joseph

- “Joseph was a righteous one” = He was Torah-observant, doing right by God and neighbor in all his ways.

Implicit characterization of Joseph

- “He didn’t want to make a public spectacle” of Mary = Joseph knew the social consequences for Mary if he were to make public the news of her teenage pregnancy.
- “He had planned to divorce her quietly” = In 1st century Jewish culture, most marriages were arranged by the parents, and engagements were legally binding. They were viewed with the utmost seriousness and were virtually equivalent to being married.

“As elsewhere in the Mediterranean world, fathers were guardians of their daughters’ virginity, arranged their marriages, and ‘gave’ them to their husbands. Witnesses and a symbolic act were essential for ‘erusin’, or Jewish betrothal; although Romans sometimes used ‘engagement rings,’ Judaism seems to have adopted this custom only later. Betrothal’s function was primarily commercial, but it was quite serious legally: dissolved only through divorce if both partners lived, betrothal similarly left the survivor of the man’s death a widow. Although a betrothed couple like Joseph and Mary did not live together or have intercourse, their union was as binding as marriage.”

Keener, Craig S. (2009). [*The Gospel of Matthew: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary*](#). Eerdmans. 90-91.

Joseph and Genesis

Notice how Matthew has woven subtle hyperlinks to Genesis throughout this narrative.

- Joseph is given direction about marrying Mary while he is sleeping. // God provides a wife for Adam while he is sleeping ([Gen. 2:18-25](#)).
- Mary is pregnant by the power of God’s Spirit, a miraculous pregnancy. // God enabled the miraculous pregnancies of Sarah/Isaac, Rachel/Joseph ([Gen. 21, 30](#)).
- When Joseph finds out Mary is pregnant, he suspects sexual promiscuity, though he wants to compassionately end the engagement. // Judah finds out that Tamar is pregnant and suspects sexual promiscuity, and he wants to mercilessly end her life ([Gen. 38:24-26](#)).

Life by the Spirit

The role of the Holy Spirit in Jesus’ conception is highlighted two times ([Matt. 1:18, 20](#)), and forms an important inclusio frame around all of [Matthew chapters 1-4](#), where the Spirit again plays a key role in the story of Jesus’ baptism by John ([3:11, 16; 4:1](#)). In the Hebrew Bible, the Spirit is associated with the creation of life.

Genesis 1:2 Instructor's Translation

Now the land was wild and waste,
and darkness was over the surface of the deep,
and **the Spirit of Elohim** was fluttering over the waters.

Genesis 2:4b-7 Instructor's Translation

^{4b} In the day when Yahweh Elohim made the land and skies,
⁵ and no shrub of the field was yet in the land,
and no plant of the field had yet sprouted,
for Yahweh Elohim had not sent rain upon the land,
and there was no human to work the ground,
⁶ but **a stream would go up from the land**
and it would water the whole face of the ground,
⁷ then Yahweh Elohim formed the human of dust from the ground,
and **he breathed** into his nostrils the breath of life;
and **the human became a living being.**

Psalm 104:29-30 NASB

²⁹ You hide Your face [from animals],
they are dismayed;
you take away their **spirit** ,
they expire and return to their dust.
³⁰ You send forth your **Spirit** ,
they are **created**;
and you **renew** the face of the ground.

Isaiah 44:3-4 NASB

³ For **I will pour out water** on the thirsty land
and streams on the dry ground;
I will pour out my Spirit on your seed
and my blessing on your descendants;
⁴ And **they will spring up** among the grass
like poplars by streams of water.

In the creation narratives of Genesis, the presence of God's Spirit as life-generator is associated with God's control of the waters. Specifically, in the Eden narrative (Gen. 2:4-3:24), the generation of life from the wet dirt takes place when God breathes into the formed mud and gives life to the human.

After this, the arrival of God's Spirit is associated with the creation of life from non-life, and it is explored from many angles in biblical poetry. Psalm 104 meditates on how life and death result from the gift or withdrawal of God's Spirit. Isaiah 44 meditates on how the rebirth of Israel after Babylonian exile will only take place when God brings a "new Eden" blessing of water and Spirit.

The miraculous births in Genesis (Isaac in Gen. 21, Jacob and Esau in Gen. 25, Joseph in Gen. 31) are all set on analogy to these "spirit-birth" stories in Genesis. This explains why the Apostle Paul equates the conception of Isaac on analogy to creation and resurrection from the dead in Romans 4.

Romans 4:16-21 NASB*

¹⁶ ... Abraham, who is the father of us all,
¹⁷ (as it is written,

“A father of many nations have I made you”) in the presence of him whom he trusted, namely God, **who gives life to the dead and calls into being that which does not exist.**

¹⁸ In hope against hope he trusted, that he might become a father of many nations according to that which had been spoken, “So shall your seed be.”

¹⁹ Without becoming weak in faith he contemplated his own body, **now as good as dead since he was about a hundred years old, and the deadness of Sarah’s womb;**

²⁰ yet, with respect to the promise of God, he did not waver in lack-of-trust but grew strong in trust, giving honor to God,

²¹ and being fully assured that what God had promised, he was able also to do.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jesus = “Yahweh Will Rescue”

The meaning of Jesus’ name (Grk. Iesous / Heb. Yeshua) is “Yah will rescue” (long form: Yehoshua).

English: Jesus

Greek: Iesous / Ἰησοῦς

Hebrew (short form): Yeshua / ישוע

Hebrew (long form): Yehoshua / יהושוע

The idea of Yahweh “rescuing” Israel from their sins is a clear signal back to the message of the Hebrew prophets that the communal disasters that came upon Israel were a result of their violation of the terms of the covenant with Yahweh. In this context, “rescue from sin” refers to the oppression by foreign nations and scarcity in the land, described in detail in the covenant curses and blessings of the Torah (see [Lev. 26](#) and [Deut. 28](#)).

In the Hebrew prophets, rescue “from sin” means from the consequences of Israel’s sinful violations of the covenant with Yahweh. And conversely, “forgiveness” and “rescue” from sin means the ending of the period of covenant curse and the time of new Eden blessing for Israel for the nations.

Micah 7:15-20 NASB

¹⁵ “As in the days when you came out from the land of Egypt, I will show you signs.”

¹⁶ Nations will see and be ashamed of all their might.

They will put their hand on their mouth,
their ears will be deaf.

¹⁷ They will lick the dust like a serpent,
like reptiles of the earth.

They will come trembling out of their fortresses;
to the LORD our God they will come in dread
and they will be afraid before you.

¹⁸ Who is a God like you, who pardons iniquity
and passes over **the rebellious act of the remnant** of his possession?
He does not retain his anger forever,
because he delights in unchanging love.

¹⁹ He will again have compassion on us;
he will **tread our iniquities** under foot.
Yes, you will cast **all their sins**
into the depths of the sea.

²⁰ You will give truth to Jacob
and unchanging love to Abraham,
which you swore to our forefathers
from the days of old.

Jeremiah 31:31-34 LEB

³¹ Look, the days are coming," declares Yahweh, "and **I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel**
and with the house of Judah, ³² not like the covenant that I made with their ancestors on the day of my
grasping them by their hand, bringing them out from the land of Egypt, my covenant that they themselves
broke, though I myself was a master over them," declares Yahweh.

³³ "But this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days," declares Yahweh: "I
will put my law in their inward parts and on their hearts I will write it, and I will be to them God, and they
themselves will be to me people.

³⁴ And they will no longer teach each one his neighbor, or each one his brother, saying, 'Know Yahweh,' for
all of them will know me, from their smallest and up to their greatest," declares Yahweh, "**for I will forgive
their iniquity and their sin I will no longer remember.**"

Jeremiah 50:18-20 LEB

¹⁸ Therefore thus says Yahweh of hosts, the God of Israel,
"Look, **I am going to punish the king of Babylon** and his land
just as I punished the king of Assyria.

¹⁹ And I will restore Israel to its pasture,
and it will feed on Carmel, and in Bashan,
and on the hills of Ephraim, and in Gilead
its hunger will be satisfied.

²⁰ In those days and at that time," declares Yahweh,
"the guilt of Israel will be sought, but there is none,

**and the sins of Judah, but they will not be found,
for I will forgive those I left behind.”**

Matthew consistently places before us moments where Jesus is the agent who releases God’s forgiveness to Israel.

“sin” = Greek *hamartia* / *αμαρτια* — “moral failing”

“release” = Greek *aphiemi* / *αφιημι* — “forgive, dismiss”

Matthew 9:2-6 Instructor's Translation

² and look, they brought to him a paralyzed-man,
laid up on a bed-mat,
and when Jesus saw their trust,
he said to the paralyzed-man,
“Have courage, child,

your moral-failings are released.”

³ And look, some of the scribes said among themselves,
“This man blasphemes.”

⁴ And when Jesus saw their thoughts, he said,
“Why are you thinking bad-things in your hearts?

⁵ What is easier, to say,
‘Your moral-failings are released’?
or to say,
‘Get up and walk’?

⁶ But in order that you can know that the son of the human has authority
on the land **to release moral-failings ...”**

Matthew 26:27-28 Instructor's Translation

²⁷ And after taking the cup and giving thanks, he gave to them, saying,
“Drink from it, all of you,

²⁸ for this is **my blood of the covenant**,
which is poured out **for the release of moral-failings ...”**

This last example from [Matthew 26](#) is crucial: Jesus views the sins he is addressing in his life, death, and resurrection as related to the covenant between God and Israel.

Son of David, Son of God

The role of the Holy Spirit in the conception and birth of Jesus is part of the narrative’s claim for Jesus’ divine identity as Son of God. The narrator makes very clear that Joseph is not to be understood as the biological father of Jesus.

However, given Joseph’s role in the genealogy of [Matthew 1:1-17](#), it is Joseph who is the descendant of David.

“In the Gospel of Matthew, it is not the son of David who is adopted by God as his son, but the reverse; it is the Son of God birthed by the Holy Spirit who is adopted into the family line of David through the action of Joseph.”

Konradt, Matthias (2020). [The Gospel according to Matthew: A Commentary](#). Baylor University Press. 35.

Jesus, Isaiah, and Immanuel

Matthew’s first “fulfillment quotation” in his account is from [Isaiah 7:14](#).

Matthew 1:22 quotation of Isaiah 7:14	Isaiah 7:14 — Old Greek Septuagint	Isaiah 7:14 — Hebrew Text
Ιδου η παρθενος εν γαστρι εξει και τεξεται υιον, και καλεσουσιν το ονομα αυτου Εμμανουηλ	ιδου η παρθενος εν γαστρι εξει και καλεσεις το ονομα αυτου Εμμανουηλ,	הנה העלמה הרה וילדת בן וקראת שמו עמנו אל:
Look, the virgin will be pregnant and will birth a son, and they will call his name “Emmanuel”	Look, the virgin will be pregnant and will birth a son, and you will call his name “Emmanuel,”	Look, the young woman is pregnant and gives birth to a son, and you will call his name “Immanuel.”
Jesus, Isaiah, and Immanuel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).		

When we compare Matthew’s quoted text of [Isaiah 7:14](#), we find two important differences from the Hebrew text of Isaiah.

- 1. Difference #1: Matthew has “they will call,” while the Hebrew text and Old Greek translation read “you will call,” referring to Isaiah himself.
- 2. Difference #2: Matthew follows the Old Greek translation in translating the Hebrew word *’almah* / עלמה as “virgin” / *παρθενος*, instead of “young woman” / *νεανις*, which is how this Hebrew word is often translated in the Old Greek Septuagint (see [Exod. 2:8](#); [1 Sam. 20:22](#); [Ps. 68:25](#) [67:25]; [Prov. 30:19](#); [Song 1:3](#), [6:8](#)).

However, this translation of “young woman” as “virgin” by the Old Greek translator is not random, and it shows an awareness of an important set of authorially intended literary analogies at work in the Isaiah scroll. Within the key chapters of [Isaiah 5-11](#) and [36-39](#), there are a broad set of intentional hyperlinks that compare the stories of a father (King Ahaz) and his son (King Hezekiah) when they were placed in similar tests of trust in Yahweh’s promises to protect Jerusalem and the future of the seed of David. (The following insights are adapted from Jacob Stromberg, “The Virgin Birth and the Book of Isaiah: Matthew’s Reception of an Isaianic Analogy,” 6-7.)

Ahaz in Isaiah 5-11	Hezekiah in Isaiah 36-39
Isa. 7:1 The Syrians and northern Israelites ally, so that a foreign king (מלך) goes up (עלה) against (על) the city of Jerusalem.	Isa. 36:1 The Assyrian army surrounds Jerusalem so that foreign king (מלך) goes up (עלה) against (על) the city of Jerusalem.
Isa. 7:6 The foreign king seeks to replace the legitimate Davidic king with someone else.	Isa. 36:14-17 The foreign king seeks to replace the legitimate Davidic king with someone else.
Isa. 7:3 Isaiah sends a message to King Ahaz “at the conduit of the upper pool on the highway to the launderer’s field.	Isa. 36:2 “... at the conduit of the upper pool on the highway to the launderer’s field.”
Isa. 7:4, 11 Isaiah says “don’t be afraid” (אל תירא) and offers a “sign” (אות) to confirm God’s promise.	Isa. 37:6, 30 Isaiah says “don’t be afraid” (אל תירא) and offers a sign (אות) to confirm God’s promise.
Isa. 7:14-15 The sign is a son to be born to a “young woman” (עלמה), who will “eat” (אכל) curds and honey until the city’s deliverance.	Isa. 37:30-32 The sign is that the remnant of Jerusalem will “eat” (אכל) plants that sprout “upward” (למעלה) and bear fruit when the city is delivered.
Despite the absence of a man “going into” the “young woman,” she will birth a son who will be a sign of the city’s deliverance and the survival of the son of David.	The king of Assyria will not be allowed to “go into” (בוא אל, Isa. 37:33-34) Jerusalem, who is described as the “virgin daughter Zion” (παρθενος θυγατηρ Σιών, Isa. 37:22).
Isaiah 37:30-35 ³⁰ “Then this shall be the sign for you: you will eat this year what grows of itself, in the second year what springs from the same, and in the third year sow-seed (זרע), reap, plant vineyards and eat their fruit (פרי). ³¹ The surviving remnant of the house of Judah, it will again take root downward and bear fruit (פרי) upward. ³² For out of Jerusalem will go out a remnant, and survivors out of Mount Zion, The zeal of the LORD of hosts will perform this.” ³³ Therefore, thus says the LORD concerning the king of Assyria, “He will not enter into (בוא + אל) this city or shoot an arrow there; and he will not come before it with a shield, or throw up a siege ramp against it. ³⁴ By the way that he came, by the same he will return,	
<i>Ahaz and Hezekiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).</i>	

Ahaz in Isaiah 5-11

Hezekiah in Isaiah 36-39

and **he will not enter into** (בוא + אל) to this city,” declares the LORD.

³⁵ “For I will defend this city to save it for my own sake and for my servant David’s sake.”

Ahaz and Hezekiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The story of Ahaz’s failed faith and the birth of the Immanuel child in his day becomes an analogy for the later successful faith of Ahaz’s son Hezekiah. The son’s faith in Yahweh’s deliverance resulted in the rescue of Jerusalem from the king of Assyria as well as survival of the seed of David.

The poem uttered by [Isaiah 37:30-35](#) about the deliverance of Zion and the seed of David takes on a future-oriented meaning, as the author has depicted the rescue of the future Zion/royal seed on analogy to the deliverance in Hezekiah’s day (see also Stromberg’s important essay, “Figural History in the Book of Isaiah: The Prospective Significance of Hezekiah’s Deliverance from Assyria and Death”).

“[T]he almah of [Isaiah ch. 7](#) functions as a portent of virgin daughter Zion in [ch. 37](#) ... [H]er child, Immanuel, was a sign of the post-Assyrian royal remnant to 'go forth' from her in the manner of a virgin birth, the image of a renewal of Davidic rule, not by the will of man but of God. Reading backwards from referent to portent, then, the Septuagint can be seen as following the historical sense of the text when it translates both בתולה in the oracle given Hezekiah ([37:22](#)) and עלמה in the sign given Ahaz ([7:14](#)) with the same Greek word, παρθενος, 'virgin'—a conclusion extending to παρθενος in Matthew’s version as well ... [T]his entire strategy—involving the Ahaz and Hezekiah narratives—has a prospective significance that points beyond the days of the prophet to a time far removed from his own—a time when God would again intervene in the life of his people to effect a renewal of Davidic rule. In portraying Jesus in precisely these terms, it was no doubt Matthew’s intention to signal that this future had arrived.”

Stromberg, Jacob. “The Virgin Birth and the Book of Isaiah: Matthew’s Reception of an Isaianic Analogy.” 9.

Reflection Question

How does Mary becoming pregnant by the power of the Spirit connect to creation in Genesis 1 and 2 or to the birth of Isaac?